at the George Enescu Festival, joined Handy, playing Bach preludes and fugues. We have a CD with an audio recording of the concert.
The MET made a donation to the Lutheran Church to repair the church organ in Archita, built in 1779. Further efforts are being made by us to raise funds for its full restoration and to rescue other organs in the region.

ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

Our work owes everything to the generosity of our donors, especially the Packard Humanities Institute and the Horizon Foundation. The Viscountess Boyd Foundation and the Headley Trust have also been very generous.

We thank Annie Appleton, Charlotte Heber-Percy, Emma Keswick, Lizzie Pitman, Michael Heathcoat Amory, Georgie Fanshawe, Rodney Leach, David Mlinaric, Anna Maciag, Thomas Gibson, Magnus and Veronica Linklater, Nick Spencer and Lazards for their generous donations, Ian Pritchett, Henry Rumbold, Seamus Hanna for all the tools donated throughout the season, and Stephen Kimbell for free transportation.

The Prince of Wales played polo on behalf of the Trust in an Exhibition Match at Cirencester Park in July. We are most grateful for the sum raised. The chairman gave a lunch at the match at which Marianne Suhr, the media star and restoration trainer, talked about our work.

Finally, we offer recognition and gratitude to our outstanding Romanian team, whose achievements in 2005 have been repeatedly commended both nationally and internationally; especially too for Codruta Vranceanu for her efficient administration, Marius Szilagyi as materials co-ordinator and Andreas Gartner as Malancrav orchard manager.

During the year ahead, we have 12 important projects which urgently need funding. A detailed report is available on each project.

THE MIHAI EMINESCU TRUST WHOLE VILLAGE PROJECT

Some of our donors may be unaware of the diversified range of our activities which now extend far beyond the building restoration work with which we originally began our work in the Saxon villages. Over the last 5 years, in the Viscri area alone, under Caroline Fernolend's direction, we have:

* Restored 105 historic buildings, including facades, walls, interiors, gates, fences, barns and courtyards.
* Equipped and endowed a local branch of the MET, enhancing the community's ability to set priorities and attract external funds.
* Set up a small network of village guesthouses based on the Landmark Trust model.
* Financed a study of flora by Dr John Akeroyd demonstrating that the pastures fulfill international criteria for protected status.
* Established a Natural Park for the Bunesti commune.
* Trained 33 plasterers and carpenters, who will receive diplomas, enabling them to create their own businesses.
* Supplied workmen for Pro Patrimonio's house restoration.
* Provided a car for the local doctor.
* Financed travel journalists to visit the area and promote ecotourism.
* Given grants for 5 bathrooms to enable villagers to accommodate tourists and trained 10 independent guest house operators.
* Set up an independent blacksmith, refurbishing his house and donating materials for his workshop.
* Supplied tools to village carpenters.
* Repaired the fire-engine house.
* Trained three young architects in conservation practice.
* Provided an 18-seater bus for the commune of Viscri/Bunesti, to enable children to commute to school and villagers to go to market.
* Raised money for the restitution of the main village street, with tree planting, benches and cobbling.
* Created detailed maps and brochures for walks and rides.
* Paid for a feasibility study for a World Bank project to create an information centre.
* Together with the World Bank, completed restoration works on the Viscri church, a UNESCO World Heritage site.
* Sponsored a local Saxon to attend a course in Wales to help villagers improve their sewage systems.
* Provided a fax machine for the town hall.
* Provided rubbish baskets made by gypsies every year
* Provided a horse and cart for regular rubbish collection.
* Restored a large room in the school for kindergarten.
* Repaired the fence and gate of the Viscri school.
* Restored outdoor dancing square.
* Planted poplar trees to line the Bunesti-Viscri road.

* * *

FURTHER INFORMATION

The achievements of the Trust are only made possible by your donations. Those made in the UK qualify for Gift Aid. We are a listed charity No 1107300 Please send cheques to The Mihai Eminescu Trust, 63 Hillgate Place London W8 7SS. For any information about our activities as well as books and brochures, please contact our office at tel/fax 0207 229 7618/0207 792 9998
Email: admin@mihaieminescutrust.org; Guesthouses: guesthouses@mihaieminescutrust.org
Crafted tours: info@realityandbeyond ; Website: www.mihaieminescutrust.org

The Mihai Eminescu Trust

Newsletter 2005

We achieved an important goal this year, the first stage of our devolution strategy, with establishment of two independent MET affiliates, one in Viscri and one in Floresti. Each of these is led and managed by resident Romanians. We also financed the setting up of village associations in Hosman and Malancrav to implement conservation and restoration and promote the village's traditions and crafts.

An equally important aspect of our strategy has been our small business training programme. We have sponsored 43 craftsmen for a Government-approved training scheme, which will license them to practise throughout Romania. We are helping Ernst Linzing, our leading conservation builder, to set up his own company. And our longstanding three-man team, trained over five years and known as the "A Team", has this year also established an independent business.


Landscape in Transylvania

We have filed a proposal for next year's Whole Village Project to the EU's "Culture 2000" programme.

Finally, we have submitted an application, together with the EPA and the Biodiversity Centre in Cluj-Napoca, for forest management to be funded under the EU Life programme. This has passed the first selection round and been referred to Brussels.

PROTECTED ZONE

Another significant goal for the Trust has been the creation of a Protected Zone in Transylvania with the backing of HRH the Prince of Wales and President Iliescu. Launched at the Sighisoara Conference in November last year, our two protected areas pilot projects are now coming to fruition. Final documentation in the form of a comprehensive and scholarly treatise which took more than a year to prepare has been presented for approval to the Romanian Academy.

The Trust has signed an agreement with the Environmental Protection Agency (EPA) in Targu Mures, to finance scientific research with the aim of including the whole of south-east Transylvania (around 75,000 hectares) into the Nature 2000 biodiversity protection programme.We have also applied to take custody of the ancient oak reserve at Breite, near Sighisoara, and our propsal has been endorsed by the Mayor of Sighisoara. We are also delighted to report that on the strength of studies prepared by a local NGO, Eco-Breite, and financed by the MET, reservation status has been extended to cover the whole Breite plateau and it has been upgraded to IUCN protection category IV.

BUILDING RESTORATION AND CONSERVATION

This year we have completed 69 restoration projects - with another 9 large, complicated buildings, such as the manor house - nearing completion.

Throughout the summer our conservation stone mason Henry Rumbold, our master carpenter Steve Finney and our master plasterer Phil Gaches – working closely with our architects Gabriel Lambescu and Jan Huelsemann – have striven to achieve the highest standards with the village builders. We have established a general certificate of competence for plasterers and stone masons in nine villages.

At the start of the season we arranged the first visit under our Craft Exchange Programme. Kevin Calpin, a master stonemason instructor from Britain, led the team with Henry Rumbold. The aim was to give the British apprentices experience of Transylvanian village life and enable them to exchange skills, ideas and techniques with the village craftsmen.

Viscri

In the Bunesti commune (comprising the villages of Viscri, Crit, Cloasterf, Mesendorf, Bunesti, Roades and Saschiz), no less than 45 projects were completed in 2005, under the inspired leadership of our Romanian director Caroline Fernolend. Many of them are more fully described on the last page of this Newsletter.

Floresti

Work has been completed on 10 houses. The major project is the Saxon church, where the MET team have been re-pointing the walls and comprehensively restoring the interior. Winter work is under way to prevent dampness in the altar area. In the centre of the village, the guest house has been completed, as has the restoration of the Orthodox parish house, raising hope that a priest will come to live in the village.

Malancrav

Malancrav is the other jewel in the Trust's crown. In a five-day summer event, the village celebrated the 700th anniversary of its first recorded documentation. The president of Sibiu county council and a Deputy from Bucharest attended the opening ceremony. The MET supported the celebrations and gave funds for a museum of traditional Saxon interiors. Caroline Fernolend and our London director Luminita Holban gave a presentation in the Saxon church and the mayor spoke appreciatively about the Trust's achievements. Many from the audience asked about our work and about how to develop new income-generating activities. One made the interesting suggestion that Malancrav (as opposed to Viscri) should focus less on attracting tourists, who might spoil its uniquely peaceful quality, and more on encouraging traditional activities such as agriculture. A tree was planted to mark the wedding of The Prince of Wales as Patron of the MET

Work on the Apafy Manor House has progressed well. Windows, doors, electricity and heating are installed, and reinstatement of the curved stone steps to the main entrance is virtually completed. The original plasterwork of the Manor was of a very high standard and thanks to Phil Gaches, who trained our builders *in situ*, the quality has been replicated. He also taught them how to make and use a running mould and how to restore the ionic columns along the front balcony. Work on the interior is proceeding over the winter. The British designer David Mlinaric visited the site in September and is generously advising the Trust on the entire project design.

We commissioned two architectural studies during the year. Silvia Demeter produced a detailed report on the Hungarian Catholic church in Malancrav and its precincts, including the priest's house, and we have now signed a restoration and long-term leasehold agreement with the Bishop of Alba Iulia. In the neighbouring village of Noul Sasesc Cristina Began completed a study of a derelict Apafy house with a view to its future restoration.

Our work in this area is not, of course, confined to its architecture. We gave the Laslea council 4,200 Euros for the repair of the road to Malancrav; we enabled a cartographer to map the surrounding forest and agricultural land, travelling on a horse lent by Doina Pieper; and since the spring high school students from Malancrav and Floresti have had a comfortable modern minibus for their Sighisoara commute, donated by the MET and The Prince of Wales.

The Malancrav orchard

The apple picking season has been good. We have 17,000 litres (20,000 bottles) in stock from 2005 and we have refreshed the packaging and presentation of the juice to appeal to Bucharest supermarket customers. We have also added to the historical collection of apple trees, rebuilt the wood storage barn and repaired and improved the juicing plant facilities. At the autumn food fair in Bucharest, our juice shored up much interest, particularly among organic shop and restaurant owners. In November in Apold, Willi Tartler, our orchard specialist held a seminar on traditional orchard management, financed by the MET.



The Manor House

Other locations

In Apold, we gave 3,000 Euros and architectural and training advice to Corona Association for the restoration of a tower house within the fortified church.

In Beia, Saschiz and Valea Viilor we have started restoration work – adding three new villages to our repertoire.

In Sighisoara, we have submitted applications for the Leathercoat-makers' Tower and the adjacent Butchers' Tower to restore them and convert them into training and education centres open to the public.

In Hosman, working with the village association, Hosman Durabil, we are financing a complex project for the rehabilitation of the 18th century mill.

In Laslea, the A Team, with an MET grant, is working on a joint MET-Intbau information centre, a project involving painstaking structural consolidation and interior and exterior restoration, which will become a landmark for the Trust.

RAISING PUBLIC AWARENESS

An important part of our work is to raise awareness of the region's heritage and its scope for sympathetic development. At the start of the year, we invited three Romanian ministers to the embassy in London to discuss the Protected Zone initiative. Also invited were members of the House of Lords, ecologists and heads of charitable foundations. After the discussion and presentations by Luke Douglas-Home and Luminita Holban, we escorted the ministers to Clarence House to meet The Prince of Wales. Luminita Holban organised a follow-up seminar in Bucharest with Culture and Environment ministers in conjunction with local mayors.

In the spring, Jessica Douglas-Home accompanied The Prince of Wales on a five-day private visit to Horezu Monastery and other nearby monastic sites; and Ben Mehedin presented MET projects to a British Council seminar for cultural NGOs at Sinaia.

In the summer, Luminita Holban participated in a seminar at Bran on heritage conservation and urbanism organised by Intbau and Timisoara University and presented our Protection Zone scheme. She also attended a Norwegian Embassy reception in Bucharest, to celebrate the completion of the three-year PREM project ("Preparing a Romanian Village for EU Membership").

Caroline Fernolend, vice-president of Fundatia Mihai Eminescu Trust, was an active participant throughout the year. At a UNDP-GEF meeting in Bucharest, she gave a presentation of the Trust's achievements in Transylvania and elsewhere; in Sibiu, she accepted the Social Responsibility Award for the Saxon villages on behalf of the MET and later took part in a women's business forum to gain support for the revitalisation of Viscri.; and she also attended a one-day seminar in Brasov on tourism development, organised by the EU's Regional Operational Programme. She is now writing a proposal for a tourism project in Viscri for possible EU funding.

On other occasions, MET representatives attended a Europa Nostra cultural meeting; they met the president of the Romanian Tourism Authority in London to discuss the promotion of Romania's cultural attractions; our eminent Trustee, Dr Noel Malcolm of All Souls, gave a talk at the George Enescu Memorial Concert at the Romanian Embassy; and Jessica Douglas-Home gave a lecture on Romania and Eastern Europe at an international festival of music.

GRANTS

The Trust's grant-giving covered a wide range of activities in 2005. In addition to other donations mentioned in this Newsletter, we:

* launched a Trust for the Jewish synagogue in Sighisoara;
* provided transport for delivering material aid gathered in Viscri for those suffering from the floods in Moldova;
* supplied builders and support for the restoration of a house in Sighisoara which will become a bistro offering traditional foods, a shop and a tourism information centre;
* enabled two university lecturers from Lublin to travel to Transylvania (they then set up a Polish website to publicise our Landmark/MET houses);
* mediated a grant from the German World Heritage Foundation for the restitution of Viscri high street (the road has now been recobbled, waste baskets and wooden benches made and placed and the village stream and water troughs improved);
* committed $1,000 towards the publication of *'Scripta Ornitologica Romaniae'*, a magazine published in Cluj-Napoca by the president of the Commission for Nature Conservation of the Romanian Academy;
* gave a grant to a researcher to locate places to stay and cultural landmarks in the Maramures, based on which we are preparing a brochure;
* gave a grant to refurbish a classroom in Light Industry High School, Sighisoara, and donated books for the primary school;
* gave a grant to Sighisoara Durabila for a public information campaign to stimulate awareness of the city's new development plan;
* acquired and donated copies of *A Day in the Life of Ivan Denisovich* and *The Gulag Archipelago* in Romanian, signed for us in Moscow by Alexandr Solzhenitsyn and destined for a cell in the Memorial Prison in Sighet, northern Romania.

TOURISM

The president of Abercrombie & Kent visited one of our villages in November. He meets regularly with the American media, and will be promoting the Saxon villages to the US market.

We have opened two more Landmark-type houses for visitors, making the total six. For those who prefer to be in a town, we recommend the flat overlooking the cobbled citadel square of Sighisoara.

The specialist travel company Reality and Beyond continues to organise carefully crafted tours to our villages, and the surrounding forests, hills and valleys, using our restored guest houses.

Following an article in the German journal, *Sighisoara News*, with a plea to émigré Saxons to return to their villages, the MET chairman has received some encouraging letters.

MUSIC

A superb clavichord built by Samuel Maetz in 1826 has been expertly restored by Edmund Handy under the auspices of the MET and the Prodan Foundation. Since then, three concerts have taken place – the final one in September was held in one of our restored houses in Biertan, the Saxon village where Maetz spent much of his life. Edmund Handy played Byrd, Buxtehude and Bartok to an audience of 40. The British concert pianist, William Howard, who had been performing in Bucharest



Edmund Handy working on the restoration of the Maetz clavichord